

dopamine fast as a way to retrain patients' dopamine receptors. Not just as a physiological solution but as a comprehensive study of a patient's entire journey with their addiction. She starts by collecting data, identifying the root causes for the addiction, and naming the problems the addiction is creating. At the end of the fast, she even works with them on next steps for incorporating the habit back into their life, if they want to, in a more manageable amount. The bulk of the dopamine fast is abstaining from the dopamine-triggering habit for a full month. Why one month? Lembke's research found an interesting phenomenon across many of her "fasting" patients. In the first two weeks, all her patients were miserable. The brain's reward pleasure pathways were starting to reprogram but weren't there yet. For patients abstaining from cannabis or sugar, their physical withdrawal symptoms peaked in the second week. After four weeks, though, the pathways were totally rewired and most patients reported positive experiences.

You can alter a lot in a couple weeks. Research shows that the brain's gray matter, which shrinks from alcohol abuse, begins reversing within just two weeks of abstinence,⁴ and 77 percent of athletes with mild traumatic brain injuries recover within four weeks.⁵

In the grand scheme of things, one month is nothing. The average life expectancy of a woman in the US is around eighty years, which means one month is 0.1 percent of your life. But it could be the catalyst for reversing one hundred years of marketing manipulation. I (Jen) believe this because it happened for me. When Travis and I were paying off our debt, I had no sense of the word "moderation." I didn't think I had a spending problem (and I didn't want to change my spending), so I went all-in on side hustling to pay off debt faster. After two months of sixty-hour workweeks, at twenty-six years old I contracted shingles. I realized I wasn't going to be able to maintain that lifestyle long-term, so I needed to focus on both my income *and* my expenses. And because shingles taught me nothing about extremes, I decided to try a no-spend challenge. I joked that I'd done several involuntary ones in college, but they were less about saving money and more about not having any money. This time I wanted to save as much money as possible as fast as possible. Over two years I did three no-spend months. By the time we made our last debt payment, I'd learned more about myself and my spending from those challenges than I ever had before.